



Hybrid future

One-on-One with Ryusuke Kashiwabara, Toshiba Storage

Toshiba is aggressively getting into the external hard drive market in India and soon plans to launch hybrid drives in the near future. We had a chance to speak to Mr. **Ryusuke Kashiwabara**, Marketing Head (ASEAN), Toshiba Storage, who told us about the upcoming Toshiba Storage products and a general overview of where the storage industry is headed



Ryusuke Kashiwabara, Marketing Head (ASEAN), Toshiba Storage

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What is your purpose of visiting India?

We have been doing business in India, but recently we have increased our product portfolio to external storage as well as 3.5-inch desktop drives. So the purpose is to visit our customers and promote our products. Also talk to the media and promote products to your readers.

Since the Thailand floods, the prices of hard drives skyrocketed. They have reduced for sure but not to the levels at which they were before the floods. So when do you see that happening?

Before the floods we had five HDD vendors, but post floods there are just three: Seagate, WD and Toshiba. So the pricing situation is different from what it was in the past. Of course due to the increase in areal density of the drive, the price will go down year-by-year or quarter-by-quarter. But that reduction will not be a sharp decline, but it will be more gradual.

Could you give us the advantages of having both the HDD and NAND memory

divisions within the same company. How does that help you?

Customers expectations are very high. We are the only one who has NAND, HDD and SSD. So even though the HDD market keeps on growing, the growth of SSD and NAND flash is higher than HDD. So the one thing that we are focussing on right now are our hybrid drives, which integrate NAND flash and HDD tech together. Recently we announced a hybrid drive. That is one of our core future products that we want to push.

Five years down the line, between these four options, which do you think will be at the top according to you: HDD, hybrid drives, SSDs and cloud storage?

If you talk about total units of shipment for HDD or SSD, cloud itself is not going to be enough because the number of HDDs shipped to those cloud data centres is not as great as the number we ship to laptop or desktop consumers. The HDD itself of one capacity is quite large for the data centre. But if you look at total capacity, the cloud itself is already quite large. Over a five year

period, the cloud storage capacity will be much bigger than what notebook, desktop or tablet will have. A large amount of data will be stored in the cloud. We see that trend and are preparing for that. Capacity wise definitely cloud, but unit-wise it will be on the consumer side. Question is will it be HDD, SSD or Hybrid drive? We want to strongly promote the hybrid drive for that segment because the people by now are very used to using tablets and smart-phones. They give you quick response, quick boot times. With traditional hard drives, you have to wait comparatively very long. So speed of is the essence. SSD is very fast, but cost itself is still high and will be high in the future if you see the cost per GB as compared to HDD.

How soon will the Toshiba hybrid drives be available in India?

We are targeting the end of this year. The purpose of this generation of hybrid drives is to promote technology itself. We want to promote the technology in the first generation and in the second generation we want to expand to all possible channels and OEMs.

What is your take on Thunderbolt external drives which are limited due to the spinning drives inside?

We also considered Thunderbolt ports, but using it for external drives does not make sense. If local PC storage has SSD and even the external storage is SSD level, then maybe using Thunderbolt with its fast interface will make sense. But at this moment because of the internal HDD performance, we have no plan to release that kind of product in our external HDD portfolio. **d**

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